

EIR 21

The EIR 21, better known as the *Express*, was one of the first steam locomotives of the East Indian Railway (EIR). It is widely believed to be a sister locomotive of the [Fairy Queen](#), both of which were manufactured by Kitson, Thompson and Hewitson around the same time. However, there are conflicting sources that suggest that the EIR 21 was built by Stothert, Slaughter and Company of Bristol. This almost 8-m-long locomotive began its operations in August 1855. It is said to have been the locomotive that ran on the Howrah–Hooghly line and, during the Revolt of 1857, transported British troops from Howrah to Raneegunge.

Initially, locomotives were not given names, and were distinguished merely by their manufacturing serial number. Known by its number 21, this engine was called EIR 21. After almost 40 years of service in 1895, EIR 21 was rechristened the *Express*. It was withdrawn from service and preserved in front of the Jamalpur Locomotive Works office in Bihar in 1901. It would be decades before it was seen again by the public, now as an exhibit at the Railway Museum in Howrah, West Bengal. While at the museum, the locomotive suffered corrosion, some of its parts went missing, and it was even permanently damaged. Unlike its sister locomotive, the *Fairy Queen*, which was restored in 1996, the *Express* was declared unfit for restoration.

More than a decade later, in 2010, this steam locomotive was finally resurrected by Perambur Loco Works of the Southern Railway. It was fitted with a new injector and air brakes and readied to run the Heritage Special Service. Its first heritage run was on 15 August 2010 – Independence Day – from Chennai Central to Avadi in Tamil Nadu with two coaches, as part of the day's celebrations.

The *Express* now boasts of various technological advancements, including a GPS-based speedometer. Today, it operates once a week as a tourists' special, carrying sightseers to and fro. The engine's restoration posed a challenge to the *Fairy Queen's* record of being the world's oldest working steam locomotive. Interestingly, the *Express's* fleet number 21